

COMPLIANCE

A Novella

*"A floor exists administratively before it exists physically —
and once acknowledged by bureaucracy, it becomes real
enough to take people."*

— Haversham Municipal Building, Internal Audit (Redacted)

PART I: THE FLOOR THAT SKIPS

The Haversham Municipal Building smelled like carpet cleaner and old paper — a scent Mara Ionescu associated with stability. Not comfort, exactly, but predictability. Forms filed correctly. Meetings held on time. Problems defined well enough to be postponed.

The elevator reflected that ethos perfectly.

It was beige, scarred with keys and rings, its buttons clouded from decades of municipal fingers. The inspection certificate inside the frame read EXPIRES: AUGUST, even though it was already October. No one worried about that. No one ever did.

Mara pressed 8.

The elevator rose with its usual muted whine. She watched the red digital numerals tick upward while reviewing a paragraph in her head — language for an upcoming compliance memo. Something about occupancy load variance. She'd been rewriting it for weeks, sanding down anything that sounded uncertain.

5

6

—

8

She frowned.

It wasn't dramatic. The elevator didn't shudder or misalign. There was no sense of vertigo, no warning chime. The display simply failed to acknowledge something it should have shown.

Mara hesitated, then stepped out onto the eighth floor.

"Probably a burnt segment," she muttered.

The explanation satisfied her enough to last the morning.

HAVERSHAM MUNICIPAL — MAINTENANCE LOG

Date: October 14

Location: Main Elevator (East)

Issue: Display segment failure (reported)

Resolution: No fault found. Display functioning within
acceptable parameters.

Tech: R. Vasquez

Note: Third report this quarter. Consider user education.

Her office was windowless, shared with three other analysts, separated by partitions that absorbed sound but not gossip. The overhead fluorescents buzzed softly, always on the edge of flicker. Someone's radio played low classical music — the same station, every day, because changing it would require a conversation.

By noon, Mara had already fielded two emails about evacuation routing diagrams.

She sighed and opened the Facilities folder.

That was when she noticed the new map.

The laminated fire evacuation diagram near the stairwell had been replaced sometime in the last week. Fresh screws. Clean edges. The kind of update no one announced because it wasn't considered news.

Mara stopped walking.

FLOOR 7

— EXIT VIA EAST STAIR

She leaned closer.

The font matched. The color coding was correct. The arrows obeyed code. Everything about the diagram was... compliant.

Except for the fact that there was no Floor 7.

The building had eight floors. Always had. Ground, then one through six, then eight. An architectural quirk dating back to a superstition from the seventies — she remembered reading it during onboarding.

She checked the rest of the diagram.

No annotations. No footnotes. No 'future expansion.'

Just a calm, official assertion that Floor 7 existed and wanted you to leave it safely.

Mara took out her phone and snapped a picture.

She told herself she'd email Facilities after lunch.

She never did.

FROM: facilities@haversham.gov

TO: shared-admin@haversham.gov

SUBJECT: RE: Lighting replacement

Completed on 7F. Ticket closed.

— Facilities Automated System

By Wednesday, the irritation had deepened into something harder to categorize.

She searched her sent mail.

No request. No ticket number. Nothing.

She forwarded it to the shared admin inbox with a single line:

"Is this a misroute?"

No one replied.

Later that afternoon, she overheard two coworkers talking near the copier.

"...so they're moving Accounting up one floor," someone said.

"Which one?" the other asked.

A pause.

"...Seven, I think?"

Mara looked up.

Neither of them noticed.

Thursday morning, the mailroom smelled worse than usual — burnt coffee and toner. A gray plastic tray sat alone on the counter, labeled in thick marker:

FLOOR 7 — INTERNAL

She stopped.

The tray wasn't overflowing. It wasn't urgent-looking. It simply existed, like it had every right to be there.

Inside were interoffice envelopes.

Handwritten names.

People she knew.

People she worked with.

Including one addressed to D. Keller.

Dan Keller had retired six months earlier. There had been cake. A speech about institutional memory. A group photo no one ever looked at again.

Mara stared at the envelope until the room felt too quiet.

She didn't touch it.

Touching it would have meant acknowledging it.

And acknowledging it would mean... something else.

She left the mailroom without collecting her own mail.

□ *Remind M. — retirement party photos still in shared drive? Check.*
— J.

Friday came with rain and a fire drill.

The alarm tone echoed through the building, practiced and dull. Everyone stood, annoyed but obedient. Clipboards were set down. Coffee abandoned.

Mara followed the posted evacuation route.

Down the stairs.

Past the landing between floors six and eight.

There, taped to the wall, was a printed instruction sheet she had never seen before.

IF EVACUATING FROM FLOOR 7:

WAIT FOR STAGGERED RELEASE

The paper was slightly crooked.

She stared at it as people flowed around her.

No one else slowed.

No one commented.

When the drill ended, Facilities sent out a thank-you email praising 'cross-floor coordination.'

Mara deleted it.

At 4:52 PM, her calendar chimed.

MEETING REMINDER

7F COMPLIANCE REVIEW

Location: Floor 7
Organizer: D. Keller
Time: 5:00 PM

Please bring all relevant documentation.

She laughed — once. Sharp and reflexive.

"This is getting stupid," she said aloud.

Her phone buzzed.

From: d.keller@haversham.gov

"Running a bit behind. Can you come up?"

Her fingers hovered over the keyboard.

She didn't reply.

She didn't need to.

Above her ceiling tiles — somewhere too close to be above the roof, and too high to be another office — a phone began to ring.

Not loudly.

Not urgently.

Just enough to be unmistakable.

Mara sat very still at her desk.

For the first time, it occurred to her that the building wasn't malfunctioning.

It was updating.

PART II: ASSIGNED

Mara didn't tell anyone about the meeting invite.

She told herself it was because there was nothing to tell — a calendar error, a stale account, some backend artifact of a retired employee who still existed in the system because no one ever truly left a municipal database.

That explanation held until Monday morning.

Her badge didn't work.

She pressed it to the reader at the main entrance, waited for the familiar green flash.

Red.

She tried again.

Red.

Behind her, someone cleared their throat — the polite, practiced sound of a coworker waiting to pass through the same inconvenience they'd all learned to tolerate.

Mara stepped aside, embarrassed.

"I think mine finally died," she said.

"No worries," the guard replied, already typing. He didn't look up. "Name?"

"Mara Ionescu."

A pause.

The keyboard slowed.

"Huh," he murmured.

She leaned forward. "What?"

"Nothing. Just—" He swiped a temporary badge from a drawer and slid it across the counter. "You're active. Just... flagged."

"Flagged how?"

He hesitated, then smiled with the careful neutrality of someone trained never to speculate.

"Floor reassignment pending," he said. "Happens all the time."

The badge was gray instead of white.

Printed on it, beneath her name, was a small line of text she hadn't seen before:

DEPT: COMPLIANCE — 7F

HAVERSHAM MUNICIPAL — HUMAN RESOURCES

SUBJECT: Temporary Reassignment Notice

Due to departmental load balancing, you have been temporarily reassigned to Floor 7.

This reassignment does not affect your pay, benefits, or tenure.

Please see attached FAQ.

Her desk had already moved.

Not physically — the desk itself was the same laminate slab, the same wobble in the front-left leg. But her belongings had been... organized.

The framed photo of her parents sat closer to the monitor. Her mug had been replaced with an identical one, clean, facing outward. Her keyboard had been swapped for a newer model, keys slightly stiffer.

Someone had adjusted her space to match a standard she hadn't agreed to.

She opened her email and found the attached FAQ.

FLOOR 7 — FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

Q: Is Floor 7 new?

A: Floor 7 has been part of the Haversham Municipal Building since its most recent capacity audit.

Q: Why haven't I been there before?

A: Many employees are reassigned before realizing it.

Q: Is this permanent?

A: All assignments are subject to review.

Mara closed the PDF without finishing it.

She tried to ask someone.

"Hey," she said to Jonah from Records, "you've been here longer than me — did we always have a seventh floor?"

Jonah blinked.

"Yeah," he said, slowly. "I think so."

"You think so?"

He shrugged. "I don't go up there much."

"Have you ever?"

Another pause.

"...Not really," he admitted. "But I know people who do."

"Who?"

Jonah frowned, searching his memory like a filing cabinet with the labels torn off.

"Accounting, maybe. Or... Compliance?" He smiled, relieved to have landed somewhere familiar. "You'll be fine. It's quieter."

That word again.

Quieter.

Her calendar began filling on its own.

Meetings with vague titles:

7F ONBOARDING CHECK-IN

INTER-FLOOR ALIGNMENT SYNC

OCCUPANCY REVIEW (MANDATORY)

Each listed a location.

Each listed Floor 7.

She declined one.

It reappeared fifteen minutes later — accepted.

At lunch, she tried the stairs.

She told herself it was curiosity, not compliance.

The stairwell between floors six and eight felt wrong the moment she stepped into it. The air was cooler there, heavier, like a basement that forgot it was underground. Sound flattened. Her footsteps arrived slightly delayed, as if the space needed time to decide they had happened.

Between the two landings, there was a door.

Gray. Unmarked.

No handle on her side.

She stood there longer than she meant to.

The door did not open.

She did not touch it.

When she returned to her desk, her inbox held a new message.

FROM: Facilities

SUBJECT: Access Attempt Logged

Please refrain from manual access between
reassigned floors.

Thank you for your cooperation.

She closed her email and stared at her hands.

They were trembling, just slightly.

The fire drill that afternoon included a new instruction.

A calm voice over the intercom:

"Employees assigned to Floor 7, please remain in place until staggered release."

Mara did not remain in place.

She walked with everyone else, heart pounding, expecting someone to stop her.

No one did.

Outside, standing in the parking lot, she noticed something strange.

The headcount clipboard included a column she hadn't seen before.

7F — PRESENT

Several checkmarks were already there.

She recognized some of the names.

She didn't see any of the people.

That evening, as she packed up to leave, she found something on her chair.

A thin folder.

Unlabeled.

Inside: a single sheet.

DESK ASSIGNMENT — FLOOR 7

Her name was already signed.

Not forged.

Not copied.

Signed in her own handwriting.

She stood alone in the office, fluorescent lights humming softly, and felt the slow, unmistakable sensation of a decision being finalized somewhere she wasn't allowed to attend.

Above her, between floors six and eight, the phone rang again.

This time, she knew who it was for.

THE SENTENCE THAT DIDN'T FINISH

It happened just before lunch, which mattered more than Mara expected.

People were relaxed then. Looser. Less careful with their words. The building exhaled around noon.

She was standing near the printers with Elliot Park from Procurement — a man whose defining trait was that he never quite finished thoughts cleanly. He spoke in parentheses, detours, footnotes to himself.

They were both waiting for a document to spit out.

"So yeah," Elliot was saying, leaning back against the counter, "I heard Accounting's moving again. Something about the load on—"

He stopped.

Not abruptly. Not like someone startled.

He just... paused.

Mara glanced up, expecting him to continue.

He didn't.

He was still there. Standing. Blinking. Mouth slightly open, like he was waiting for the next word to arrive.

"—on?" she prompted.

Elliot frowned faintly, as if confused by her interruption.

"Sorry," he said. "What was I saying?"

"Accounting," Mara replied. "You said the load on—"

"Right," he nodded. "Yeah. They're trying to balance it better. You know how it is."

The printer whirred.

Mara waited.

Elliot smiled politely, the conversation clearly over in his mind.

"Anyway," he said, and reached for his papers.

He turned.

And didn't finish the motion.

One moment, his shoulder was there — wool blazer, frayed cuff.

The next, the space beside her was empty.

No sound.

No rush of air.

No distortion.

Just... absence.

The printer continued humming.

Mara's brain lagged behind her eyes.

She looked down.

The papers Elliot had been waiting for were neatly stacked in the output tray.

On the cover sheet, in bold type:

DELIVER TO: PARK, E. — 7F

Her stomach dropped.

"Elliot?" she said.

Her voice sounded too loud.

Someone behind her cleared their throat.

"Printer's jammed again?" a woman asked, already reaching past Mara.

Mara turned.

"Did you—" She stopped herself. Tried again. "Wasn't Elliot just here?"

The woman frowned, then smiled apologetically.

"I don't think so."

Mara looked around.

Three people stood nearby. None of them looked confused. None of them were searching the room with their eyes.

One man shrugged. "You mean Ethan?"

"No," Mara said. "Elliot. Procurement. He was literally—"

She gestured at the empty space.

The gesture felt foolish even as she made it.

The man followed her hand, then nodded slowly.

"Oh," he said. "Him."

Relief flared in her chest. "You remember him?"

"Sure," he said. "But he doesn't work on this floor anymore."

"When did he leave?"

The man hesitated.

"Earlier than you think," he said, with a faint, uncertain laugh. "Later than it feels like."

He walked away.

Mara returned to her desk in a fog.

She pulled up the internal directory.

PARK, ELLIOT

STATUS: ACTIVE

LOCATION: FLOOR 7

She checked the timestamp.

Updated nine minutes ago.

She checked her sent mail.

An email sat there she did not remember writing.

TO: e.park@haversham.gov

SUBJECT: Re: Load balancing

Makes sense. Let me know how 7F handles it.

— M. Ionescu

Sent: [TIMESTAMP ERROR — +2:00 OFFSET]

Her reply was timestamped two minutes in the future.

Mara closed her laptop.

She pressed her palms flat against the desk, grounding herself in the chipped laminate, the familiar wobble of the leg.

Around her, the office continued.

Phones rang.

Someone laughed.

The building absorbed Elliot Park the way it absorbed sound — without echo.

And somewhere between floors six and eight, a sentence finished itself.

PART III: OCCUPANCY

By Tuesday, the building was colder.

Not everywhere. Not enough to justify a maintenance ticket. Just... selectively.

Mara noticed it first near the stairwell.

The air between floors six and eight had taken on a weight to it — the kind you feel before a storm, or in archives where humidity control runs a little too well. Sound behaved differently there. Conversations flattened. Footsteps softened, like they were being absorbed by carpeting that didn't exist.

She paused on the landing, hand resting on the rail.

Her skin prickled.

She checked her watch.

Still running.

Still ticking forward.

That mattered more than she wanted it to.

Her inbox had begun returning things she didn't remember sending.

Not spam. Not drafts.

Completed messages.

FROM: facilities@haversham.gov

SUBJECT: Returned item — Misplacement resolved

Personal item retrieved from 7F and returned
to origin point.

Thank you for your patience.

When she arrived at her desk, her scarf lay folded neatly across her chair.

She had left it at home.

The wool was cool, as if it had been stored somewhere underground.

Attached was a small adhesive tag, the kind Facilities used for asset tracking:

ORIGIN VERIFIED — FLOOR 7

She did not put it on.

□ *Check supply closet — extra forms? Someone keeps taking the 7F requisitions.*
— R.V.

People spoke more slowly now.

Not everyone. Not obviously.

But pauses lingered too long. Sentences softened at the edges. Words like "before" and "after" were used less frequently, replaced with "currently" and "pending" and "as needed."

Time had begun to behave like policy language.

Mara noticed something else, too:

No one said seven anymore.

They said "upper reassignment."

They said "restricted floor."

They said "that level."

Numbers were avoided with the quiet instinct people use around topics that cause paperwork.

She tried the stairwell again at lunch.

This time, the gray door was warm to the touch.

Not hot. Just... occupied.

She didn't press her ear to it — she didn't need to.

She could hear typing.

Soft. Distant. Rhythmic.

A printer cycling.

The faint murmur of voices speaking in careful, professional tones.

Office sounds.

From a floor that did not exist.

Her phone vibrated.

FROM: HR@haversham.gov

SUBJECT: Occupancy Confirmation

Please confirm your continued presence on
assigned floor for safety compliance.

[CONFIRM] [DEFER]

She hit DEFER.

The phone buzzed again immediately.

Thank you for confirming.

Her throat went dry.

The fire drill that afternoon was not announced.

No alarm.

Just a voice, calm and close, issuing instructions over the PA:

"Employees assigned to Floor 7, please remain seated. Occupancy is stable."

Mara remained standing.

Around her, chairs creaked as people sat back down.

Some looked confused — briefly. Then relieved.

She realized then that she was the only one holding her breath.

At 3:17 PM, the elevator doors opened on the eighth floor.

She hadn't pressed the button.

She stood inside the car, staring at the gap.

The digital display glowed red:

7

The doors did not fully open.

They parted just enough to reveal... depth.

Not darkness. Not light.

A compressed space, like an office viewed through frosted glass.
Desks arranged too close together.
Ceiling tiles lower than regulation.
People seated, unmoving, their movements slowed as if processed through a buffer.
She saw Elliot Park.
He was typing.
He paused mid-keystroke and looked up.
Not at her.
At something just past her shoulder.
The doors slid shut.
The elevator continued upward.
When it opened on eight, no one else seemed to notice she had gone pale.
Her desk assignment updated that evening.
A new placard appeared without explanation, affixed neatly to the partition beside her monitor:

IONESCU, M. — COMPLIANCE

PRIMARY DESK: 7F

SECONDARY DESK: 8F (TEMPORARY)

Temporary.
That word again.
She checked the building directory.
The total employee count had not changed.
Neither had the square footage.
Occupancy load remained within acceptable limits.
Everything balanced.
Mara stayed late.
The lights dimmed automatically around her.
Somewhere above the ceiling, a chair rolled back.

A voice murmured, "Almost done."

She didn't know who said it.

She knew they meant her.

THE ONE WHO TRIES

It was Linda Morales who tried to help her.

That mattered, because Linda was real in the way only certain people were real — middle-aged, union-represented, blunt to the point of rudeness. She worked Payroll. She knew where bodies were buried because she processed their benefits when they stopped needing them.

Linda didn't speculate.

She corrected.

"You look like hell," Linda said, standing in Mara's doorway with a coffee she hadn't been invited to take. "And don't tell me it's allergies. I've done allergies. This is paperwork stress."

Mara didn't answer.

Linda set the coffee down anyway. Sat. Lowered her voice.

"You've been moved," she said. Not a question.

Mara nodded.

Linda exhaled through her nose. "Okay. Good. Because that's fixable."

Something in Mara cracked at the word fixable.

"They reassigned me to a floor that doesn't exist," she said.

Linda blinked once.

Then shrugged. "Yeah. That tracks."

Mara stared.

"Oh don't look at me like that," Linda said. "I've been here twenty-two years. This building eats people. Usually slowly."

She pulled a manila folder from her bag.

Not new. Worn. Soft at the corners.

"I keep copies," Linda said. "Of things that get... smoothed."

She opened it.

Inside were printed payroll stubs. Old ones. Some decades old.

Names Mara recognized.

Names she didn't.

Each stamped with the same annotation, in different handwriting styles across the years:

LOCATION ADJUSTED — NO PAY CHANGE

Linda tapped one.

"This is where they go," she said. "Or where the system says they go. Doesn't matter which. The fix is to make noise early."

"Noise how?" Mara asked.

Linda smiled grimly. "By being a problem."

HAVERSHAM MUNICIPAL EMPLOYEES UNION

GRIEVANCE FORM — SECTION 7.3.1

Nature of Complaint: Reassignment without notice

Floor Affected: [REDACTED]

Date Filed: [BLANK]

Status: PENDING

Note: This form has been filed 14 times since 1987.

No resolutions on record.

They went together to HR.

That mattered too.

Two people. Witnesses.

Linda spoke calmly. Used dates. Referenced policy. Quoted subsection numbers from memory.

"This reassignment violates three labor agreements and one fire safety statute," she said. "You cannot assign staff to a non-enumerated floor."

The HR rep nodded sympathetically.

"Yes, we can," she said. "We have."

Linda leaned forward. "Then show me the certificate of occupancy."

The HR rep's smile didn't waver.

"It's under review."

"By whom?"

"Facilities."

Linda stood.

"Great," she said. "Let's go."

Facilities was empty.

Not abandoned. Not dusty.

Just... unused.

Lights on. Phones off-hook. Chairs pushed in.

On the central table lay a stack of folders.

Each labeled in black marker:

7F — PENDING

Linda picked one up.

Flipped it open.

Her name was on the first page.

MORALES, LINDA

ROLE: PAYROLL

STATUS: TRANSITIONAL

EFFECTIVE: IMMEDIATE

Linda laughed.

Once.

Sharp.

"Cute," she said. "They think they're clever."

She pulled out her phone.

No signal.

She frowned. Tried again.

The building hummed.

Mara felt the temperature drop.

"Linda," she said quietly. "We should go."

Linda shook her head. "No. This is the part where you don't go."

She stepped toward the door.

It did not open.

Not locked.

Just... unwilling.

Linda turned back, jaw tight.

"Okay," she said. "Fine."

She squared her shoulders.

"Here's what's going to happen," she said, louder now. "I am filing a grievance. I am contacting the union. I am—"

She stopped.

Mid-sentence.

Mara felt the moment stretch.

Linda blinked.

Her mouth moved.

No sound came out.

Then she frowned — not in fear, but irritation.

"Hang on," she muttered. "I lost my train of—"

The sentence never returned.

Linda's badge slid from her lanyard.

Clattered to the floor.

Mara lunged forward.

Linda wasn't gone.

She was... less.

Her outline blurred, like someone viewed through too many reflections. Her cardigan sagged, empty at the shoulders.

Her voice came back — softly, professionally — from somewhere above them.

"Payroll is up to date," it said. "Benefits will continue without interruption."

Linda's body folded inward.

Not violently.

Neatly.

As if filed.

The folder on the table stamped itself.

STATUS: ACTIVE

LOCATION: FLOOR 7

The room warmed again.

The door opened.

Mara ran.

Later, when she checked the directory, Linda Morales was listed as present.

Her extension rang.

No one answered.

Mara returned to her desk shaking.

On her chair was a sticky note, in Linda's handwriting.

□ *Don't let them call it temporary.*

— L.M.

Mara sat down.

The building had tried negotiation.

It had failed.

Now, it would proceed.

PART IV: THE FLOOR

Mara finished the report at 10:43 AM.

She knew this because the timestamp embedded itself automatically at the bottom of the document:

OCCUPANCY IRREGULARITIES — FINAL REVIEW

Submitted: 10:43

Location: 7F

She stared at that last line for a long time.

Then she looked up.

The ceiling was lower.

Not enough to notice immediately — just enough that the fluorescent panels felt closer, more intimate. The hum they made was softer here, tuned down, like the building didn't want to startle anyone.

Her desk was smaller.

Or maybe she was.

The partition walls curved inward slightly, rounding off corners that had once been square. The carpet beneath her feet was thinner, worn smooth by traffic that didn't leave footprints.

Around her, people worked.

Slowly. Politely. Carefully.

No one spoke above a murmur.

No one stood.

No one looked surprised to see her there.

Mara's stomach dropped — not in panic, but recognition.

She hadn't arrived.

She had been here for a while.

Her monitor blinked.

A new email arrived.

FROM: onboarding@haversham.gov

SUBJECT: Welcome

We're glad you could join us.

Most people say the adjustment period passes quickly.

- ☑ Desk assigned
 - ☑ Access verified
 - ☑ Orientation acknowledged
 - ☑ Secondary workspace released
-

Released.

She closed the email.

Her phone buzzed.

No signal bars.

Just a notification.

Calendar Update: All future meetings relocated to 7F.

She stood.

The floor did not creak.

It absorbed the movement like it had been expecting it.

She walked.

Rows of desks extended farther than the building's footprint should allow. The space folded inward on itself — not endlessly, just efficiently. There were no windows. No clocks. No exit signs.

There were personal items.

Photos.

Plants.

Mugs with faded logos.

Lives reduced to what could be kept at a desk.

She passed Elliot Park.

He looked older.

Not much. Just... settled.

He typed slowly, methodically, his posture perfect.

"Elliot," she said.

He looked up.

Smiled.

"Oh," he said. "You made it."

Her throat tightened. "How long have you been here?"

Elliot considered this.

"Depends how you count," he said. "But it gets easier."

"Easier than what?"

"Than noticing," he replied, and went back to typing.

At the far end of the floor stood a wall.

Blank.

Unbroken.

No door.

No signage.

Just smooth drywall.

Mara pressed her palm against it.

Warm.

Occupied.

She leaned her forehead there and closed her eyes.

For just a second.

When she opened them, the wall was gone.

In its place: another row of desks.

Another compliance team.

Another version of her name printed on placards.

She staggered back.

A hand caught her elbow.

Linda Morales.

Whole.

Intact.

Smiling gently.

"There you are," Linda said. "I was worried you'd get stuck in transition."

Mara's breath hitched. "Linda— I saw you—"

Linda shook her head.

"Paperwork," she said kindly. "You can't trust what you see before placement stabilizes."

She gestured around them.

"This is where we make sure people don't fall through the cracks."

Mara looked into Linda's eyes.

They were calm.

Empty in the way a balanced ledger is empty.

"You don't feel it?" Mara whispered.

Linda frowned. "Feel what?"

Mara let go of her.

Linda returned to her desk.

The chair did not scrape.

Mara sat at her own desk.

Her hands rested on the keyboard.

They knew where the keys were.

Muscle memory didn't fight.

The cursor blinked.

Patient.

Above her screen, taped neatly to the partition, was a note in Linda's handwriting.

□ *Don't let them call it temporary.*

Mara swallowed.

She opened a new document.

Typed the only honest sentence she had left:

I am still here.

The system underlined "still."

Suggested replacement: assigned

She accepted.

The underline vanished.

The document saved itself.

Somewhere far above — or below — an elevator skipped a number.

The building adjusted.

Occupancy remained within acceptable limits.

And Floor 7 continued, quietly, doing the work it had always been meant to do.

PART V: COMPLIANCE

The notice went out on a Thursday.

Not marked urgent.

Not flagged for review.

Just another internal memo, auto-distributed at 9:00 AM.

FROM: Facilities & Operations

SUBJECT: Building Directory Update

Please note the following adjustments to floor access and occupancy listings, effective immediately.

No one read past the first paragraph.

Those who did found nothing unexpected.

The building directory was updated by noon.

Floor listings now read:

Floor 1 — Public Services

Floor 2 — Records

Floor 3 — Licensing

Floor 4 — Planning

Floor 5 — Legal

Floor 6 — IT

Floor 7 — Compliance

Floor 8 — Administration

The spacing was correct.

The font was consistent.

The building had always had eight floors.

A new evacuation map replaced the old one by the stairwell.

The arrows were clearer now.

No curling edges.

No annotations.

If you stood long enough to study it, you might notice that the route from Floor 7 did not intersect with any other floor until it reached the outside.

That was considered a safety improvement.

HUMAN RESOURCES — CASE CLOSURE NOTICE

STATUS: RESOLVED

REASON: CAPACITY REALIGNMENT

No appeals logged.

No grievances remain open.

Payroll balanced.

Benefits continued.

No dependents flagged as affected.

From a systems perspective, nothing has been lost.

On Monday, a new analyst started.

Her name was Claire Whitby.

She arrived ten minutes early, badge freshly printed, hair still damp from the rain. The guard smiled and handed her a temporary pass.

"Floor seven," he said.

She hesitated.

"Oh," she replied. "I thought Compliance was on eight."

The guard checked his screen.

"Not anymore," he said pleasantly. "But you'll get used to it."

Claire's desk was waiting.

Clean. Standard issue.

A mug sat neatly beside the monitor.

It read:

STILL HERE

She assumed it was a joke.

She smiled.

At 10:43 AM, a document auto-generated in the system.

OCCUPANCY REVIEW — ANNUAL

AUTHOR: IONESCU, M.

LOCATION: 7F

Staffing levels: STABLE

Workflow: UNINTERRUPTED

Floor utilization: WITHIN ACCEPTABLE MARGINS

"No further adjustments anticipated."

The document was approved without comment.

That afternoon, someone in Administration noticed the elevator skip a number.

They frowned.

Pressed the button again.

It worked normally the second time.

They made a mental note to mention it to Facilities, then forgot as soon as their phone rang.

The building remained quiet.

Productive.

Balanced.

And on Floor 7, people continued to work — slowly, politely, carefully — finishing reports they had started mid-sentence, answering emails sent from addresses that no longer existed, maintaining systems that required no oversight because they now maintained themselves.

Mara Ionescu's desk remained occupied.

Her chair was warm.

Her hands moved steadily across the keyboard.

She did not look up when Claire walked past.

There was nothing left to notice.

END